

Introduction to the Philosophy of Religion

Introduction

The philosopher Slavoj Žižek has a nice joke that he uses to exemplify the Marxist concept of ideology and the psychoanalytic concept of the unconscious that I think is helpful to orient ourselves to the study of religion. It goes like this:

There is a pair of parents, a mother and father, who are preparing Christmas decorations for their children. Among the preparations, they are presenting a representation of Santa Claus which will come and surprise the children. So somebody asks them, “Hold on, do you really believe this is Santa Claus?” And the parents reply: “No, of course not, we’re just doing this for the kids.” Then afterwards, they ask the children, “Do you really believe Santa Claus is coming?” And they answer: “No, of course not, we’re just doing this for our parents.” In other words, nobody believes in Santa Claus, and yet the belief in Santa Claus still functions. This example helps us introduce the question of the *philosophy* of religion - which is to ask the question what we mean when we say that someone “believes” in a religion.

This is how I would like to open this question of how to introduce ourselves to the study of the philosophy of religion. We often want to think of religion in terms of belief; namely, what do you believe in, and whether it is true, which is to say, whether it is the case; whether these claims obtain in reality. In other words, we treat religious studies and theology and the philosophy of religion as if they were scientific questions. In our so-called “modern world” we have had many scientific theories, including evolution or the copernicern revolution, which have presented a challenge to particular conceptions of religion and cosmology. Very famously, the Soviet cosmonaut Gherman Titov stated that when he had gone to space he had seen “no angels or gods”. In other words, we have become so inculcated into the type of thinking that science invites us into that it has become to us synonymous with our conception of truth and reality.

Science has shown us an extraordinary amount about the history of the cosmos and of our species: the universe is approximately 13.8 billion years old; the earth approximately 4.5 billion years old; and Homo sapiens emerged in Africa at least roughly 300,000 years ago. Modern humans subsequently migrated out of Africa and eventually populated most of the world. One wonders what else the species was up to in all that time. But there are some questions that science does not seem to be able to answer.

But there is one question that remains that science simply cannot answer, in virtue of the type of inquiry which it consists in. In Martin Heidegger’s *Introduction to Metaphysics* he states that the metaphysical question par excellence is the question “why is there something rather than nothing?” Through this question, Heidegger wants us to enter into a different way of thinking, which is how he introduces what metaphysics is; namely, that metaphysics is the field of inquiry that asks what is being, what is the difference between being and nothing, and what are the

ways in which Being appears for this particular being, namely, the human being, or what Heidegger calls Dasein, the “being-there!”

So, in this similar vein, I want to ask a related question: namely, what is religion, this term which in its Latin etymology (*religio*) has been variously associated with careful observance, with “rereading” (*relegere*), and, in a later Christian etymology, with “binding again” (*religare*)? Even the etymology, therefore, raises more questions.

So we ask the question: what is religion? Immanuel Kant, another one of my favorite philosophers, states in *Religion within the Bounds of Mere Reason* that religion is “the representation of our moral duty as divine commands.” In other words, he starts with the unconditional demand that the moral law places on us concludes that practical reason directs us toward what he calls the “highest good,” in which virtue and happiness correspond. Because human beings cannot themselves guarantee such a correspondence, Kant argues that practical reason gives us grounds for postulating God and immortality. Hence, Kant believes that it is rational for us to believe in a god who can grant us grace in proportion to our virtue so that we can continue to strive towards the perfection that the law demands even after we have fallen short.

What interests me in particular is the distinction Kant makes between rational religion and historical faith; he states that there is only one true religion (of the moral law) but many (historical) faiths. But this raises up a philosophical and historical question of its own. If religions are historically and culturally distinct, is that difference evidence they cannot simultaneously be true? Or could these different religious traditions be articulating a truth that exceeds any one of them?

Part I: A History of Religions

One way to approach these questions is by looking at “Hinduism” - which describes an enormous network of traditions that are organized around family traditions, rather than a single religion that had one founder or creed or canon.

A summary of the Hindu Scriptures:

Hinduism doesn’t have a closed canon like the Christian Bible (which itself was produced in response to Marcionism). Instead, there are different kinds of scripture most importantly *śruti*, or that which is “heard,” and *smṛti*, or that which is “remembered.”

But among the most commonly accepted bodies of Hindu literature are:

1. The Vedas
2. The Puranas
3. The Upanishads
4. The Ramayana
5. The Mahabharata, where the Bhagavad Gita is found

The Vedas are hymns to the old gods, primarily Indra and Agni. They are the thunder and fire gods, respectively. They're revered as part of the oldest surviving strata of Vedic religious literature and contain hymns, prayers, and ritual material associated with sacrifice and the ordering of the cosmos.

The Upanishads focus on philosophical questions: the nature of the self, Brahman, death, rebirth, knowledge and liberation, and features King Yama, whose role is to judge souls for reincarnation, revealing the secrets of life and death to his servant.

The Puranas are not simply commentaries on the Vedas, but large collections of mythology, cosmology, genealogy, pilgrimage traditions and devotional narratives associated particularly with deities such as Vishnu, Shiva and the Goddess.

The Ramayana is the great epic which narrates the life of Rama, an incarnation of Vishnu. Ravana, the king of Lanka, has acquired extraordinary powers through a boon from Brahma and threatens to awaken Brahma from his cosmic dream and therefore end reality. Shiva approaches Vishnu in the highest heaven and asks him what is to be done about this calamity. Hence, Vishnu incarnates as Rama, to give humanity an example of how to live a life in accordance with dharma, or duty towards the moral law. The story recounts the birth of Rama, his marriage to Sita, his exile, the abduction of Sita by Ravana, the war against Ravana, and his subsequent return to Ayodhya.

The Ramayana therefore depicts one of the great Hindu reflections upon what it means to act according to dharma: justice, obligation, kingship, family, fidelity and the ordering of human life.

The Mahabharata is another story about a complicated political drama that takes place between Duryodhana and the Kauravas, on the one hand, and his cousins, the five Pandava brothers: Yudhishthira, Bhima, Arjuna, Nakula, and Sahadeva, on the other. It gets very complicated by the end!

However, through this familial civil war, the epic expands a political conflict into an enormous religious and philosophical reflection upon dharma, violence, justice, kinship, death and the divine.

This story also features the scene depicted as the Bhagavad Gita, which is the revelation of Lord Krishna as an incarnation of Vishnu, and his song to Arjuna, who is depressed when he sees his former mentors and beloved teachers on the other side of the battlefield against him, on the nature of war, conflict, the soul, the divine, morality and duty. Krishna urges him to understand his duty within a reality that exceeds his individual perspective, while also teaching different paths involving action, knowledge and devotion.

What seems important in all this, however, are the many roles that a single "religion" already takes: hymn, sacrifice, metaphysics, mythology, creation story, moral law, political epic, devotion and philosophical argument. In other words, already here, we can see that religion cannot simply be reduced to things individuals either do or do not believe.

Part II: Religion and History

But as far as religion goes, we have to read simultaneously the text of these scriptures, like the Hebrew Bible, against the historical-critical backdrop of modern science and archaeology.

And my contention is, if we read the historical-critical scholarship properly, the text of scripture makes more sense, not less. I think the findings of the historical-critical method contextualize the claims the Bible makes about itself, rather than disprove them.

Namely: the Canaanite and West Semitic origins of early Israelite religion; the post-exilic influence of Zoroastrianism on Judaism; and the ways these historical relationships are themselves attested in the scripture's narrative of itself.

When Abraham is called from Canaan, the Hebrew Bible establishes a continuity between this first "Canaanite" or "pre-Israelite" religion and the Abrahamic covenant. The historical-critical view of this is that ancient Israelite religion is a variation of Canaanite and West Semitic religion, but this continuity is even attested in the scripture's narrative of itself when Abraham receives the blessing from the high priest, King Melchizedek, king of Salem and "priest of God Most High." Much later, the author of Hebrews draws on Melchizedek again to describe Christ's priesthood and establish the continuity of the new covenant with what came before it.

There is another example after the Babylonian exile. Contemporary scholarship now believes that there is a significant influence of Zoroastrianism on post-exilic Judaism, but this relationship is even reflected in the biblical narrative: Cyrus the Great, the Persian king who liberates the Jews from Babylon, is called God's *mashiach*, his "anointed," in Isaiah. The gospel writers later mention the Magi, which is a traditional name for Zoroastrian priests, who visit Jesus at his birth.

In other words, I think the findings of the historical-critical method contextualize the claims the Bible makes about itself, not disprove them. Rather, it is through the historical development of a religion that its truth becomes specified to the people who articulated it. Religions develop through encounters, conflicts, inheritance, and transformations of what came before them.

There's also this notion of normative inversion in Moses that Jan Assmann explores in the book *Moses the Egyptian*. Assmann explains that it is through this structure of inversion, which is widespread in religious history, which birthed the "Mosaic distinction" between true and false religion, typically associated with biblical monotheism. He also discusses Freud's reading of historical-critical theory, which is fantastic because Freud does the same maneuver which he does in *Totem and Taboo* in the book *Moses and Monotheism* on the origins of his own Judaism. Freud's view in this book argues that Mosaic monotheism was really the result of the Egyptian pharaoh, Akenaten, and that the historical Moses was a governor who had been exiled for having been associated with his regime. In other words, Freud posits that Judaism emerged from an internal difference within "so-called" paganism, rather than conceiving of either paganism or Judaism as being pure types which are independent of each other. Although this is a highly speculative thesis, the point Freud raises is relevant to us here: namely, that religion can produce something new by transforming what it has inherited from previous structures.

Nietzsche performs something comparable in a very different register. In *Ecce Homo*, Nietzsche credits Zarathustra as being the originator of our tradition of Western monotheism through a process that he calls the “transvaluation of all values”. It was the prophet Zoroaster who invented our “modern values” and hence, the first to realize what went wrong and, therefore, the first to return. But again—Nietzsche is inviting us to think of religion not in terms of systems of propositions about what to believe, but ways of conceiving of values which have their own genealogies that occur through continuity, rupture, inheritance, and inversion.

Part III: One Religion, Many Faiths?

I remember talking to my TA in the Augustine class, saying that I am struggling with my Indian heritage and Christianity, but I agree with most of the Christian doctrines otherwise; he asked which ones I believe in. I said, “Well, I’m a theist, a trinitarian, and I believe in the hypostatic union, and...” “So you believe in the whole thing?!”

“Ya.”

But this is where the question of religious pluralism, as well as an affirmation of difference, becomes important to me. In this perspective, salvation is not merely individual but rather it is new creation; that is, God’s love for the world to both create it, as well as to be joined to it in consummate love; and hence a desire for a new heaven and a new Earth. But affirming particular Christian doctrines does not seem to me to require believing that every other religious tradition is false; but also that it doesn’t seem to affirm their difference, either, by saying they are all different ways of talking about the same reality.

Christianity speaks of incarnation and the hypostatic union; Islam speaks of prophecy and revelation; Buddhist traditions speak of awakening, nirvana and, in some Mahayana traditions, Buddha-nature; Hindu traditions speak in various ways of avatara, liberation and divine manifestation. However, although these concepts are different; we must compare and consider them before concluding that they either describe the same metaphysical event, as well as state that they are irreconcilably different. In fact, when read in light of one another, it reveals a reality that is even more majestic and powerfully consonant than they do in isolation; like the anarchist Proudhon has said, “it is the clash of ideas that casts the light”.

So what’s the point of all this? Well, in my view, ultimately, salvation simply *is* the beatific vision, which is the new life and new resurrection when we are face to face with God, which is why Jesus describes it predominantly in economic terms: that the first shall be last and the last shall be first; or, in other words, the future arrives, re-writes the past and redeems the earth.

This doesn’t mean that salvation, nirvana, moksha, and other concepts of other religions are simply saying the same thing; rather, their identity and difference gives us an opportunity to think the possibility of affirming the highest values of these incommensurate traditions simultaneously—to imagine what type of reality can paradoxically produce all of these

articulations, and to see in all of these historical inheritances of religions a shared common horizon on the meaning of the Earth.

This brings me back to Kant. Kant states that there is only one true religion, the religion of the moral law, but many historical faiths. But the question becomes what to make of the relationship between our natural, historical religions as products of long processes of our traditions self-reflexive understandings of themselves, as well as our moral freedom, which demands of us the fullest ethical autonomy and dignity to be afforded, both to ourselves, as well as to every sentient being; i.e., to love our neighbors as ourselves.

But I think it is a mistake to think of truth as unified and singular. Truth is not centered; it is polyvalent and dispersed, like language itself. Each of these religions is a population's self-reflexive understanding of their own relationship to nature, and their own narration and relationship to the land and to the divine. Each linguistic structure, in each natural language, achieves its full consciousness in these two forms of what I think of as the common horizon of nature and ancestor worship, or the Sefirot/Shekhinah in Judaism, or Shiva/Shakti in Hinduism, or Christ as Bride and the Church as the Bridegroom in Christianity.

Simone Weil gives me one particularly interesting example of this problem. Weil was profoundly drawn to Christ and described mystical experiences of Christ, yet she refused baptism into the Catholic Church. At the same time, she found profound spiritual meaning outside Christianity, particularly in Greek thought and in Indian religious literature. Whatever we make of her particular judgments, she confronted the possibility that genuine encounter with the divine might exceed the institutional and historical boundaries by which religions ordinarily distinguish themselves from one another.

Which brings us back to the question we started with in the beginning: what is religion? We often want to think of religion in terms of belief; namely, what do you believe in, whether it is true, whether these claims obtain in reality. But religion cannot simply be reduced to things individuals either do or do not believe. As we have already seen, religion takes the form of hymn, sacrifice, metaphysics, mythology, creation story, moral law, political epic, devotion and philosophical argument. And it takes place within the shared horizon of nature and history, as traditions we encounter, inherit, transform and sometimes intervert into one another.

Hence, before asking "Which religion is true?" we have to return to the question asked by Pontius Pilate at Christ's crucifixion, "What is truth?" Or, what do we mean when we say a religion is true? How did we get to the "Mosaic distinction" between true and false religion? If religious truth is always mediated by particular languages, histories and people, then perhaps the plurality of religions is not a problem standing in the way of truth, but rather the very form through which truth appears at all.